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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

Author(S): Baba Of Karo, Smith, Mary Felice

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 243

Culture (OWC): [Hausa \(MS12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1949-1950

Coverage Date: Ca. 1900-1950

Place Coverage: Nigeria

Section Title(S)

My Adopted Daughter's Marriage and her First Childbirth

When the ceremonies of betrothing the couple and setting the day for the marriage were complete (we do them both at once nowadays), (³⁰²) the girls and young men went off and the officials and elders went home. We, the kinsfolk, divided up the gifts. In the evening when everyone had dispersed, 'Yardada returned from market with the things I had sent her to buy.

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Two months later on the tenth day of the month, 'Yardada went to Fagaci's compound with her *kawa*, who is now Waziri's wife, and a daughter of the pipe-players. They all hid somewhere in Fagaci's compound. I said to her *kawa* Gambo and her *yaya* Soda, 'If you have hidden her and you don't produce her tomorrow or the day after, what will become of the feast?' They said 'Where's the hiding-money?' I said 'Go and see the bridegroom, he'll give you a shilling and Talle will put on her henna'. Off they went to Talle, her joking relation in the blacksmith's compound—isn't 'Yardada a daughter of the Buzaye, the Sokoto people, so won't she joke with a blacksmith's daughter? Talle was a grown woman with children. (³⁰³) The *kawaye* went to Fagaci's compound to look for the bride, then the wailing began. I heard her wailing and my body began to tremble like this, I did not want to be parted from her. Fagaci was in his entrance-hut and the wailing annoyed him. 'Come come, 'Yardada,' he said, 'you're going to Yelwa's compound, the marriage compound, and you're crying? Cheer up, don't cry!' After she had had her first child and she came to Fagaci's compound with her child on her back to greet her friends, he said 'Is it you, 'Yardada, have you grown up like this? Where's the wedding weeping

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now?' Then she fled inside the compound! I sent her *kawaye* to the bridegroom to get the hiding-money, but when they returned they refused to bring the bride, they came to me looking for her, and I said she wasn't with me. 'The bridegroom has given us kolanuts,' they said; 'Right,' I said, 'then go and put the henna on her.' Then they went and indicated where she was, they went and stood outside Fagaci's compound, then Talle arrived and went into the compound and seized her and put the henna on  244 her while 'Yardada cried and struggled, *kichi-kichi*. Talle ran away with 'Yardada after her, saying she was going to beat her. When Talle caught them in the hut, she and the girls were crying and shouting, throwing themselves on the ground and saying 'Alas, marriage has eaten up 'Yardada!' They all fell in a heap on top of her; the *kawaye* were weeping, if the tears wouldn't flow they put spit on their eyes instead! It was in the midst of this that Fagaci came into the compound and said 'Quieten them down and take them home'. Then my daughter and about fifty boys and girls all came to my hut. They were wailing and we, the elders in the compound, were also weeping for 'Yardada. Then the drummer came to the entrance of the compound with his drum, and when 'Yardada heard the deep drum she started to cry all over again.

Baba implies that the ceremonial stages of marriage are passed through more quickly today than would be proper fifty years ago, when she was young, but it is possible that the time differences may be traditional variations of practice between Kano and Zaria.

Talle is chosen to act as 'grandmother' as she is a **joking** relation of 'Yardada's, as also are grandparents. This **joking relationship** is of the kind between ethnic and occupational groups, not between real kinsfolk.

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